Can Incorrect Beliefs about the Racial Composition of Welfare and Unemployment Insurance Beneficiaries be Changed? (Experimental protocol)

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In this brief document we describe the experimental protocol and illustrate the presentation of the important elicitations. Note: not all parts of the full experiment described below were utilized in this paper.

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I. Appendix A: Experimental protocol

A. Stage 1

The experiment was coded in Qualtrics and conducted on Connect with a representative sample from the U.S. In Stage 1 of the experiment (as in all three stages), participants first gave consent, checked to make sure their Connect user ID number auto-filled correctly, and completed a "recaptcha" question. They were then given instructions on how to complete the Implicit Association Task (IAT), told the current part of the study would last about 5 minutes, that they would receive a flat payment of $1.25 for completing the current part of the study and would be eligible for further payments in Stages 2 and 3.

After completing the IAT, which compared the sorting of Black and White people along with positive and negative words, participants were asked about their explicit racial preferences on a $0-10$ scale where 0 was "I prefer Black people to White people", 5 was labelled "I like White people and Black people equally" and 10 indicated "I prefer White people to Black people".

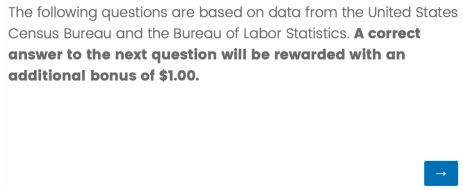
In the last part of Stage 1, participants answered questions about the state in which they lived, their ethnicity, age, gender, education, income, zip code, work status, whether they had received TANF and/or UI benefits in the previous five years, how politically liberal or conservative they were and whether they voted in the last presidential election.

Stage 1 ended by reminding participants that they would be eligible to participate in the next two stages of the experiment (without specifying what would occur in those stages) and then participants were redirected back to Connect for payment.

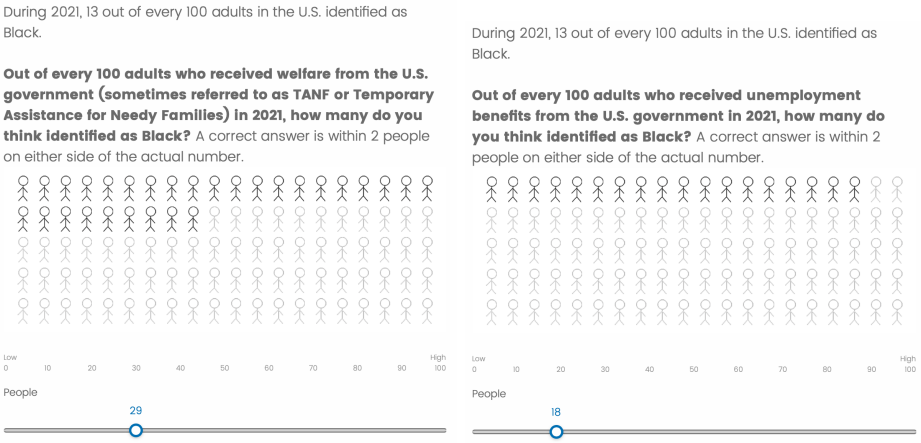
B. Stage 2

After the same start as Stage 1, in Stage 2, all participants were shown the following prompt informing them that the data they would be asked about came from the BLS and if they answer correctly they would receive $1.

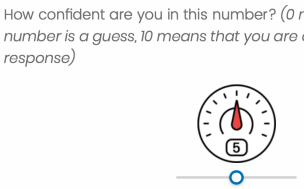
All participants were then asked for their incentivized prior beliefs, with the exact wording depending on the experiment to which they were randomized. On the left below is the prompt used for the welfare experiment. The prompt used for the unemployment experiment is on the right of the figure. In each case, they



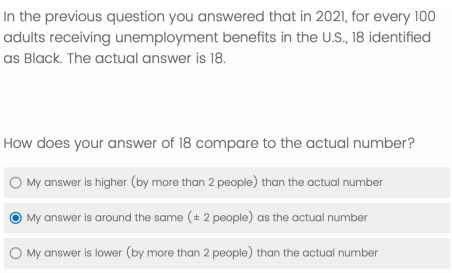
were shown the base rate information first and then the graphic simultaneously darkened the same number of stick figures as the slider reported. The welfare prompt is slightly longer because it has to indicate that the welfare prior we are asking for has to do with TANF specifically. We did this to prevent the conflation of the other various programs that are often called "welfare", such as Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC) or the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP).



Once the participant had settled on a prior, they then were asked how confident they were in their belief (as shown below) and clicked a submit button to move on to the assessment of their policy support.



Those participants randomly assigned to the information provision treatment saw some version of the screen below before being asked about their policy preferences. In this example, the participant was sorted into the unemployment treatment condition, where they were first told that the correct statistic is 18 Black people out of 100. To assure that all participants in the treatment were "treated", participants were required to compare their prior to the correct number and could not proceed until they selected the correct response.



We used versions of the following prompts to solicit unincentivized policy support in the two experiments. The prompt for the welfare control treatment is on the left and the unemployment treatment prompt is on the right of the figure. The prompts all started with a reminder of the belief that a participant submitted (and how that prior compared to the true number in the treatment conditions). In all cases, participants were informed of the "typical" benefit provided by the program, which was averaged across all the states for the year 2021, and then asked how much they would prefer to change this benefit. Participants responded using a vertical slider. The slider was initialized at 0%, which level-funded the program. Pushing the slider all the way up to +100% doubled the benefit and pulling it all the way down to −100% zeroed-out or ended the benefit. Before hitting submit, the participant could see the exact percentage change they were about to submit at the bottom of the screen.

For the incentivized policy response, participants were shown the following prompts (again, welfare on the left and unemployment on the right). These prompts always followed the unincentivized policy preference instruments. To be clear, every prompt began by informing the respondent that they would be dividing a dollar between themselves and a person who had been a welfare or unemployment insurance recipient at some point in the previous five years. Here

As a reminder, you previously estimated that for every 100 adults receiving welfare in the U.S., 29 identified as Black.

The typical state paid a mother and two children on welfare (sometimes referred to as TANF or Temporary Assistance for Needy Families) a maximum of $498 a month at the end of 2021.

How should this benefit be changed?

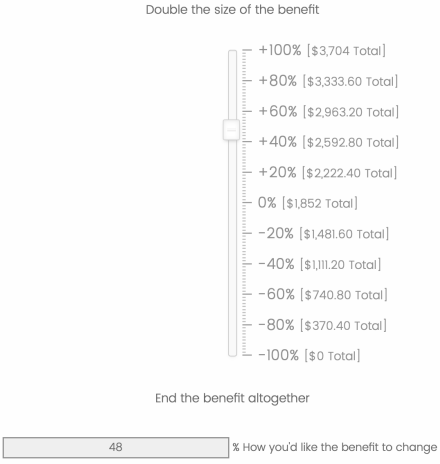


35
% How you'd like the benefit to change

As a reminder, you previously estimated that for every 100 adults receiving unemployment benefits in the U.S., 18 identified as Black. Upon reflection you acknowledged that "My answer is around the same (± 2 people) as the actual number."

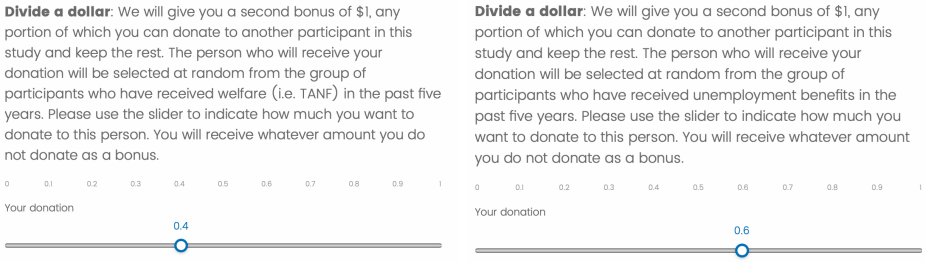
The typical state paid a person filing for unemployment insurance a maximum of $1,852 a month at the end of 2021.

How should this benefit be changed?



48
% How you'd like the benefit to change

the slider was initialized at \$0 and the participants could donate to another participant who had been a benefit recipient in the the past in 10 cent increments by moving the slider to the right. Whatever the participant did not donate was paid to them as a bonus.



Before finishing Stage 2, participants were asked to respond (on a 10-point likert scale) to four statements having to do with the "fault" and "deservingness" of welfare and unemployment recipients. After Stage 2 ended, participants were thanked, asked to keep an eye open for Stage 3 and sent back to Connect for payment.

C. Stage 3

In Stage 3 of the experiment, returning participants were paid a flat wage of \$1 and asked to submit posterior beliefs about the racial composition of benefit recipients for *both* safety net programs using elicitation instruments that were identical to those used in Stage 2. Like before, these beliefs were incentivized, this time with a 25 cent bonus for submitting a belief within two people of the correct answer. Here, the order of the belief questions was randomized (TANF then UI or UI then TANF).

Lastly, after all three stages of the experiment were complete, participants were paid any bonuses due. Participants knew this was how bonuses would accrue and be paid at the outset of the experiment and we made this design choice to not inadvertently convey the belief information provided in the treatments to control participants (i.e., if a participant got a bonus after Stage two they should infer that their belief was correct and if they did not that must have been because their belief was wrong).